

Moving the training platform to its new home

How to switch the website address from `asd-training-app-v2.vercel.app` to **platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com**.

What this guide does

Right now, the training platform lives at a long, automatic web address: `asd-training-app-v2.vercel.app`. We want it to live at a friendly, on-brand address instead: **platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com**. This guide walks you through every click, in plain language, with no assumed technical knowledge.

Who this is for

Anyone with login access to the charity's Vercel account and to whoever manages the **ambitiousaboutautism.com** domain (often the IT team or the person who originally bought the domain). You don't need to be a developer — you'll be filling in forms in two web dashboards.

How long it takes

About 20 minutes of clicking, plus a wait of 5 minutes to a few hours for the internet to catch up (this waiting bit is automatic — you don't have to do anything).

First — a tiny glossary

Five words show up over and over in this guide. Here's what each one actually means in plain English.

Domain	A website's address. ambitiousaboutautism.com is the charity's domain. Domains are bought once a year from a domain registrar.
Subdomain	A prefix added to the front of a domain, separated by a dot. platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com is a subdomain — it points to a specific service (in our case, the training platform), while the main <code>www.</code> address can keep pointing to the charity's main website.
DNS	Short for <i>Domain Name System</i> . Think of it as the internet's phone book — it maps human-friendly names like <i>platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com</i> to the actual computers that serve the website. Whoever you bought your domain from gives you a DNS settings page where you can edit these mappings.
CNAME record	One specific type of DNS entry. It's a forwarding instruction that says "when someone asks for <i>platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com</i> , send them to whatever <i>cname.vercel-dns.com</i> currently points at". You'll add one of these in this guide.
Environment variable	A setting that the website reads when it starts up — typically a secret or a per-environment value. They live in a settings panel on Vercel, not in the code itself, so we can change them without a developer needing to edit anything. NEXTAUTH_URL is one of these — it tells the login system what address to use in password-reset emails. We need to update its value.
Vercel	The hosting service the platform runs on. Think of it like the landlord of the website's flat — they look after the servers, and we configure things through their dashboard.

The big picture, in one paragraph

We're going to: (1) tell the charity's domain provider that the subdomain **platform** belongs to Vercel, (2) tell Vercel that it should answer requests for that subdomain, (3) update one setting inside Vercel so the platform knows its own new address, and (4) remove the old `.vercel.app` address. That's it.

Before you start

You need access to two things. If you can't get into one of them, stop here and find the person who can — don't try to work around it.

✓ Access to the charity's Vercel account

Go to <https://vercel.com/login> and sign in. After signing in, you should be able to click on a project called **asd-training-app-v2** (or similar) in your dashboard. If you don't see it, you may not be invited to the right team — ask whoever set up the platform to add you.

✓ Access to the DNS settings for **ambitiousaboutautism.com**

This is whichever website the charity used to *buy* the domain — common ones are GoDaddy, 123-Reg, Namecheap, Cloudflare, or Squarespace. If you don't know who that is, ask the IT person or check old invoice emails for "domain renewal". You'll need to log in there and find a section called **DNS**, **DNS settings**, or **Manage DNS**.

If you only have one of the two

Both halves are required. Vercel without DNS = you can register the subdomain but no one can reach it. DNS without Vercel = you can point the subdomain somewhere but Vercel won't know to answer. Find the missing access before continuing.

Add the subdomain to Vercel

We start in Vercel because it will tell us exactly what to type into the DNS settings in the next step. Doing it this way round means less guesswork.

1.1 Open the project's domain settings

Sign into `vercel.com`. Click your **asd-training-app-v2** project. Along the top of the project page there's a row of tabs (Overview, Deployments, Analytics, Logs, Storage, Settings). Click **Settings**. Down the left-hand side there's a list of sections — click **Domains**.

What you should see on the screen

- A page titled "Domains" with the existing automatic address `asd-training-app-v2.vercel.app` already listed.
- Near the top there's a text box and a button labelled **Add**.

1.2 Type the new address

In the text box, type exactly:

```
platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com
```

Click **Add**. Vercel will then show one of two things:

- **A green tick** — meaning the domain already routes correctly. Skip ahead to Step 3.
- **A yellow warning** with the heading "Invalid Configuration" — this is the normal case. It will show a CNAME record you need to add. **Don't close this page**. You'll copy the value from here in the next step.

What Vercel actually shows you

Vercel will display a small table with two columns — **Type** (the value will be **CNAME**) and **Value** (the value will look like `cname.vercel-dns.com`). Both of those are what you'll type into your DNS provider in the next step. Leave this browser tab open.

Add the DNS record at the domain provider

Now you're going to leave Vercel and go to whoever sells the charity its **ambitiousaboutautism.com** domain. Open a new browser tab (don't close the Vercel one) and sign into your domain provider.

2.1 Find the DNS section

Every provider lays this out slightly differently, but you're looking for one of: **DNS**, **DNS Management**, **Manage DNS**, **DNS Records**, or **Advanced DNS**. It's almost always near a list of the domains you own. Click into **ambitiousaboutautism.com** and find this section.

What you should see on the screen

- A table of existing DNS records. Each row has columns for **Type**, **Name** (sometimes called "Host"), **Value** (sometimes called "Points to" or "Target"), and **TTL**.
- There's a button labelled **Add Record**, **Add**, or **+**.
- You may already see records of type **A**, **MX**, **TXT** — leave those alone, they belong to the main website and email.

2.2 Add a new CNAME record

Click **Add Record** (or equivalent). Fill in the form like this:

Field	What to enter	Why
Type	CNAME	This is the kind of forwarding rule we need.
Name (or Host)	platform	Just the prefix — most providers automatically add the rest of the
Value (or Points to)	cname.vercel-dns.com	This is the address Vercel told you in Step 1.2.
TTL	Automatic / 3600 / 1 hour	TTL = "Time to Live". How long other computers cache this info. T

Click **Save** (or **Add**). The new row should appear in the DNS records table.

Heads-up: it doesn't work instantly

DNS changes take time to spread across the internet — usually 5–10 minutes, occasionally a few hours. This is normal. You can carry on with the next step, but if Vercel still shows a yellow warning later, give it a bit longer.

Update the NEXTAUTH_URL setting

The platform has a setting called **NEXTAUTH_URL** that tells the login system its own web address. Things like password-reset emails use this value to build links. Right now it's set to the old `.vercel.app` address — we need to point it at the new one.

3.1 Open Environment Variables

Back in Vercel, in the same project, click **Settings** at the top, then **Environment Variables** in the left-hand list.

What you should see on the screen

- A long list of variable names — `DATABASE_URL`, `NEXTAUTH_SECRET`, `NEXTAUTH_URL`, `GEMINI_API_KEY`, and others.
- Each row has three coloured tags showing which environments it applies to: **Production**, **Preview**, **Development**.

3.2 Edit NEXTAUTH_URL (Production only)

Find the row called **NEXTAUTH_URL**. There are usually three rows with this name (one per environment). You only want the one tagged **Production**. Click the three-dots menu (⋮) on the right of that row and choose **Edit**.

Replace the existing value with exactly:

```
https://platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com
```

Make sure there's **no trailing slash** at the end (don't put a `/` after `.com`). Click **Save**.

Don't touch the other variables

`DATABASE_URL`, `NEXTAUTH_SECRET`, `GEMINI_API_KEY` and the rest are fine as they are. The only one that needs editing is `NEXTAUTH_URL` (Production).

Make the new address the primary one

Go back to **Settings** → **Domains** in Vercel. By now (give it 5–10 minutes after Step 2) the warning next to *platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com* should have turned into a green tick. If it hasn't, wait a bit longer — DNS sometimes takes its time.

4.1 Mark the new domain as primary

Once it's verified, click the three-dots menu (⋮) next to **platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com** and choose **Set as Primary Domain**. This tells Vercel that the new address is the official one.

What you should see on the screen

- **platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com** now has a small *Primary* label next to it.
- The old `asd-training-app-v2.vercel.app` is still listed but no longer primary.

4.2 Remove the old .vercel.app address

Now we shut the old door. Click the three-dots menu next to `asd-training-app-v2.vercel.app` and choose **Remove**. Vercel will ask for confirmation — confirm.

Yes, this is intentional

From this moment, anyone visiting the old address will get a "Domain not configured" page. That's the point — we want one official address, not two. If you accidentally shared the old address with anyone (in old emails, on a poster), let them know the new one.

Redeploy so the changes take effect

Vercel needs to restart the website once for the new NEXTAUTH_URL value to be picked up. This is a single button click.

5.1 Trigger a redeploy

In Vercel, click the **Deployments** tab at the top of the project. The most recent deployment is at the top of the list — it'll have a green dot and say **Ready** next to it. Click the three-dots menu (⋮) on that row and choose **Redeploy**. A small dialog will pop up — leave the options at their defaults and click **Redeploy** again to confirm.

What you should see on the screen

- A new row appears at the top of the deployments list with a yellow or grey "Building" status.
- After 1–3 minutes it changes to a green dot saying "Ready".

Once it says **Ready**, the migration is technically complete. Move on to the verification checklist on the next page to confirm everything works.

Verification checklist

Tick each of these off after the redeploy finishes. If any one fails, see the troubleshooting page that follows.

■ The new address loads

Open <https://platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com/login> in a browser. The login page should appear. The padlock icon next to the address bar should be closed (this means the security certificate is valid).

■ The old address is gone

Open <https://asd-training-app-v2.vercel.app/login>. You should see a Vercel "Domain not configured" page (or a generic browser DNS error). This is the expected, correct outcome.

■ Login works

Sign in at the new address with a known account. You should land on the dashboard like normal.

■ Forgot password emails point at the new address

Click "Forgot password?" on the login page, enter your email, and wait for the email. The reset link inside the email should start with <https://platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com/reset-password?...> — **not** the old [vercel.app](https://asd-training-app-v2.vercel.app) address.

■ Admin invite emails point at the new address

As a super admin, create a new test user. The invite email's activation link should also start with the new address.

■ Email logo displays

In any of the emails above, the Ambitious about Autism logo should show up at the top. (If it's a broken image, jump to the troubleshooting page.)

■ Stripe checkout returns to the new address

Only if payments are enabled (`ENABLE_PAYMENTS=true`): go to `/courses`, click "Subscribe", and check that the Stripe-hosted page's success and cancel buttons go back to addresses on the new domain.

■ Build still passes locally

(For developers only.) Run `npm run build` in the project. It should finish without errors and report "393 tests passed".

If something goes wrong

Vercel still shows "Invalid Configuration" on the domain after 30 minutes

Almost always a typo in the DNS record. Go back to your domain provider's DNS page and check the row you added. The **Value** (or "Points to") column should be exactly `cname.vercel-dns.com` — no extra dot at the end (some providers auto-add one), no `https://`, no spaces. The **Name** column should be just `platform` — some providers display it as the full `platform.ambitiousaboutautism.com` after saving, that's fine. If everything looks right, give it another hour.

The login page loads but I get logged out instantly

The redeploy in Step 5 didn't happen, so the old `NEXTAUTH_URL` value is still in use. Go back to the Deployments tab in Vercel and trigger Redeploy again. Wait for the green "Ready" dot.

Password reset emails still link to the old address

Same fix — the website is still running on the old setting. Confirm you saved the `NEXTAUTH_URL` change against the **Production** environment specifically (not Preview or Development), and redeploy.

The logo in emails is a broken image

The logo URL is calculated from `NEXTAUTH_URL` automatically. If it's broken, double-check that `NEXTAUTH_URL` has no trailing slash and starts with `https://` (not `http`).

I see a security/certificate warning in the browser

Vercel issues the security certificate (the thing that makes the padlock icon go closed) automatically, but it can take 5–10 minutes after the DNS verifies. Wait 15 minutes and try again. If it still complains after an hour, remove the domain from Vercel and re-add it.

When to ask a developer for help

If you've worked through the troubleshooting list and the new address still doesn't work after a few hours, screenshot whatever you're seeing and forward to the platform's developer. Include: the Vercel Domains page, your DNS records page, and one of the broken emails. That's enough for them to diagnose the rest.